

CLICKITY-CLICK

Agent 001 hits the streets to find the ideal keyboard and mouse

Ah! Finally got my hands on *Unreal Tournament 2004*. After a few hours of adrenaline pumping action from my professional, well greased gaming skills, I finally overcame the game in record time—3 seconds faster than Agent 000—my brother! Yay! Kabloooy! Sniff sniff! Huh? What was that? Oh damn! I spilled coffee on my keyboard in my excitement. Oh well, time for new keyboard, Agent 000 can pay for it—after all, he lost the bet.

So, after a quick trip to 000's ATM, I was off to Lamington Road, Mumbai's haven for all things electronic. I want something with hotkeys to launch the heat-seeking rockets in *Unreal*.

The first shop had an Acer keyboard for Rs 550. "No way", I thought. The next shop had a wall lined with keyboards, but when I asked the shopkeeper to recommend a reliable multimedia keyboard, I was told, "Yeh sab deewar par hain naa, see for yourself! They're all good keyboards". It was obvious this guy treated keyboards like potatoes, and probably sold them by the kilo as well...

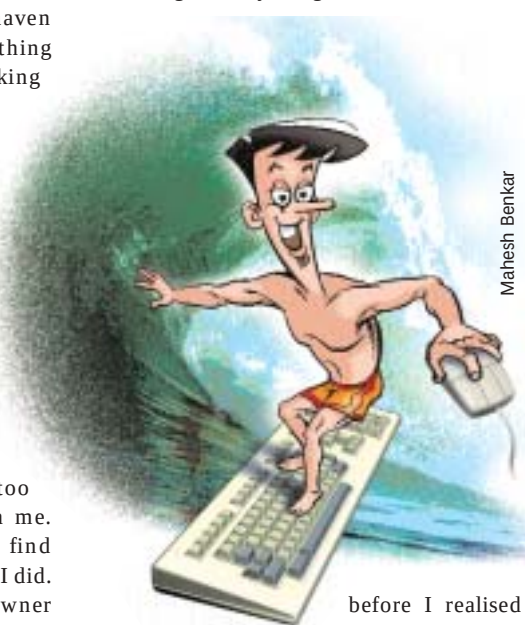
The next shop owner seemed too interested in his phone call than in me. Now, while shopping, if you fail to find what you want...cross the street; and I did.

I walked into a shop and the owner seemed excited to see me—it was obvious from all the scribbled-on paper lying about that business was slow here today. "Good for me", I said to myself. They always pay

attention to you when they're hard-up for customers. He showed me an Odyssey multimedia keyboard, but I didn't want to look at unheard of brands. "Show me the good stuff," I said.

With a smile, he told me about the Microsoft optical combo pack of wireless mouse and keyboard. Controlling my 19-inch flat screen from the bed itself, now that would be something.

Whilst I was daydreaming, I was just nodding to everything the owner said, and



before I realised it, he had started writing up a bill. "Wait," I shouted, "How much did you say it costs?" "Only Rs 5,400, Sir," he replied.

I awoke coughing and sputtering; the owner was splashing water on my face. Muttering my thanks, and blaming the episode on those damn *vada pavs*, I beat a hasty retreat. I decided to stick to shady alleyways; at least if I meet muggers I can deal with there. I wandered about, making a mental list of what's available...

Microsoft wireless combo: Rs 3,850, but it uses 4 batteries that only last five hours.

Logitech wireless combo: Rs 3,150, and has a one-year warranty.

Microsoft optical wireless combo: Rs 5,400. Gasp! You don't win that much money at *Unreal* match-ups.

Samsung Multimedia keyboard: Rs 450, but oh, so boring.

McDonalds veg burger: Rs 30. Yummy!

That decided it, I really was hungry. I ordered a *sev puri* from a roadside stall, and noticed a tiny shop that was even smaller than this *chaat* stall. While my eats were being prepared, I walked in and looked around. The owner was polite and told me that he would recommend the Typhoon wireless combo.

For just Rs 1,450, I would get an RF wireless multimedia keyboard and an ambidextrous mouse. He also showed me a Neotech option for the same price, which comes with an integrated trackball. I was delighted, and was all set to buy it when I found that it was an infra-red-based keyboard. There's no way I want to always keep my PC in the line of sight of the keyboard—wireless without the freedom of movement is not wireless at all.

When I asked about the batteries, he said "Nahi nahi, no batteries needed". Not wanting to waste my money on peripherals that run on the energy of our souls, or on the goodwill of society—especially when the box says "4 AA batteries needed"—I went back out to eat my treats.

The *Mumbaiyya* snack gave me enough energy to continue this quest, and onwards I trudged.

I came across an iKey combo at the next stop, with a wireless keyboard and a wireless optical mouse for Rs 3,250. The receiver looked like a UFO, but the mouse wasn't ambidextrous. Since I'm a firm believer in the equality of handedness, I decided this just wouldn't do, and asked to see more.

He showed me a white Microsoft wireless combo for Rs 3,100, and a different Microsoft combo that looked much better because it was black, for Rs 4,150. The mouse that comes with this combo has horizontal scroll as well. He also had a Logitech model for Rs 3,200.

As soon as he told me that the Microsoft models carried a 3 year warranty, my mind was made up. With a little extra money, I could buy peace of mind. I decided to save what I could, and bought the Microsoft Wireless Optical.

This was still good enough to show off, had the option of either PS/2 or USB connectivity and was cheap enough to buy from my winnings. ■



■ Remember that wireless input devices look cool, but need batteries. You'll go broke buying new AA batteries every five days.

■ An RF wireless solution is better than the infra-red version, as you won't have to worry about line-of-sight.

■ An optical mouse is better in the long run as it has almost zero maintenance and better precision.

■ Look for models with the maximum warranty. Microsoft offers three years, and it's advisable to spend that little extra for peace of mind.